

Exercise:

UX Design and Customer Journey

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Intro

Product design is one of your most powerful and effective activities as an entrepreneur. An easy-to-use and fun-to-use product or service is not only a unique selling point, but it also helps reducing costs in support, minimizing in returns of goods and increases customer satisfaction, retention and reduces marketing costs thanks to viral word of mouth.

Customer Journey (CX)

The customer journey (also referred to as customer experience, CX) outlines the interaction between the customer and the company that offers a product and service. The journey starts even before the purchase, in the awareness phase (for instance, a future customer reads about your offered solution in an ad) and research phase (a future customer evaluates your product and others on the Internet). It ends at the end of the product lifecycle, ideally before the next purchase (lifecycles are short for, let's say, the Angry Bird app, and very long for a life insurance or a mortgage).

The following exercise is important to improve the overall experience of your product or service. Please be prepared to create a bullet point list with 20-60 bullets for each of both scenarios a) and b)

Envision a) your ideal customer how she would learn about your offerings, how she would then compare your product with other competitor's products and how she checks out at the shop on your webpage, which payment card she uses, how it is delivered on time through Swiss Post until, the person disposes the product through recycling at the end of the product cycle after a few years and then she considers to buy another, new product from your brand.

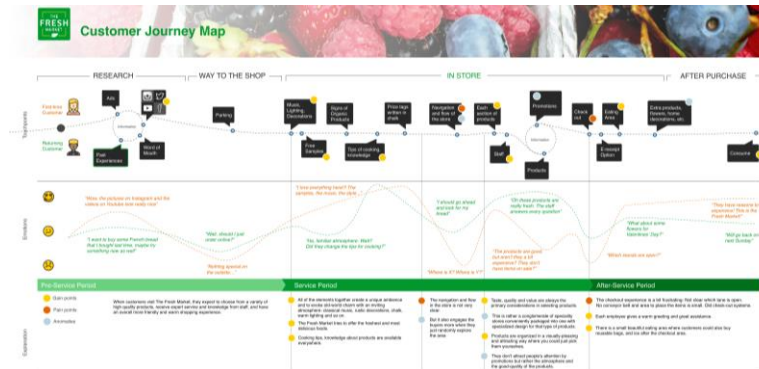
Now, envision b) an unlucky fellow that struggles picking an offer because of ambiguous product labelling. The person then cannot access your website because of an outdated browser he uses. At checkout, the credit card is declined or he has none of the offered methods of payment. After an hour long wait in the queue for the support hotline the call center assistant cannot help. After years of frustrated usage, the customer decides for your competitor's product. For the sake of the exercise, the unlucky fellow is insanely patient and willing to continue the journey until the end of the product lifecycle.

Each stop of the customer journey should be listed as a bullet point. Each bullet point becomes a column in a grid with the following rows:

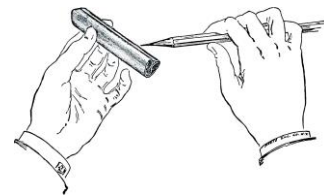
- illustrate the steps with a storyboard (like "a person on a daily commute on the train")
- indicate the channels (like "visits homepage on mobile phone")
- included in each phase and phrase the customer goals for this specific phase (like "wants to find the cheapest option")
- specify the consumer expectations ("wants to save money")

- emotional state between sad, neutral and happy (“after paying, feeling is neutral”)
- touchpoints (“an ad of Facebook”)
- potential problems (“shop might be closed on Sundays”)
- ideas (“have a 24-hour shop with a vending machine”)

Connecting the emotional states creates a curve as shown in the illustration below.



A customer journey map illustrating the emotional rollercoaster of a customer from research to end-of-life.



*A hand-drawn sketch.
Your sketch does not need
to have the illustrative
quality, of course.*

User Experience (UX) Design

As Wikipedia defines, User Experience (UX) design is the discipline to increase satisfaction in an overall positive user experience, such usability, accessibility and pleasure provided in using a product or service.

So, all elements that make a product easier, self-explanatory and more intuitive to use, are important. This already starts with packaging that does not require a tool to open. You can help with big buttons, low entry barriers, few input fields, etc.

Please do the following exercise, even if your product already exists. Expect to create at least 20 A4 pages of sketches for this very important exercise. Do not use the computer for this, but a real pen and paper.

In an ideal world, there would be only perfect products. Imagine, you have all advanced technology and all needed resources at hand. Now, create a paper-prototype of your product.

For an app or website, create A4 sheets with all screens that a user sees for the first 40 seconds. For instance, draw the loading screen. Then, on a second sheet, draw the input mask for the login window. Then, draw a third sheet with the username filed out in the input field on the login screen, etc.

For a physical product, draw the product in all steps between the unpacking until it is operational and used for one cycle. Think of it as a assembly manual like you know if from IKEA furniture.